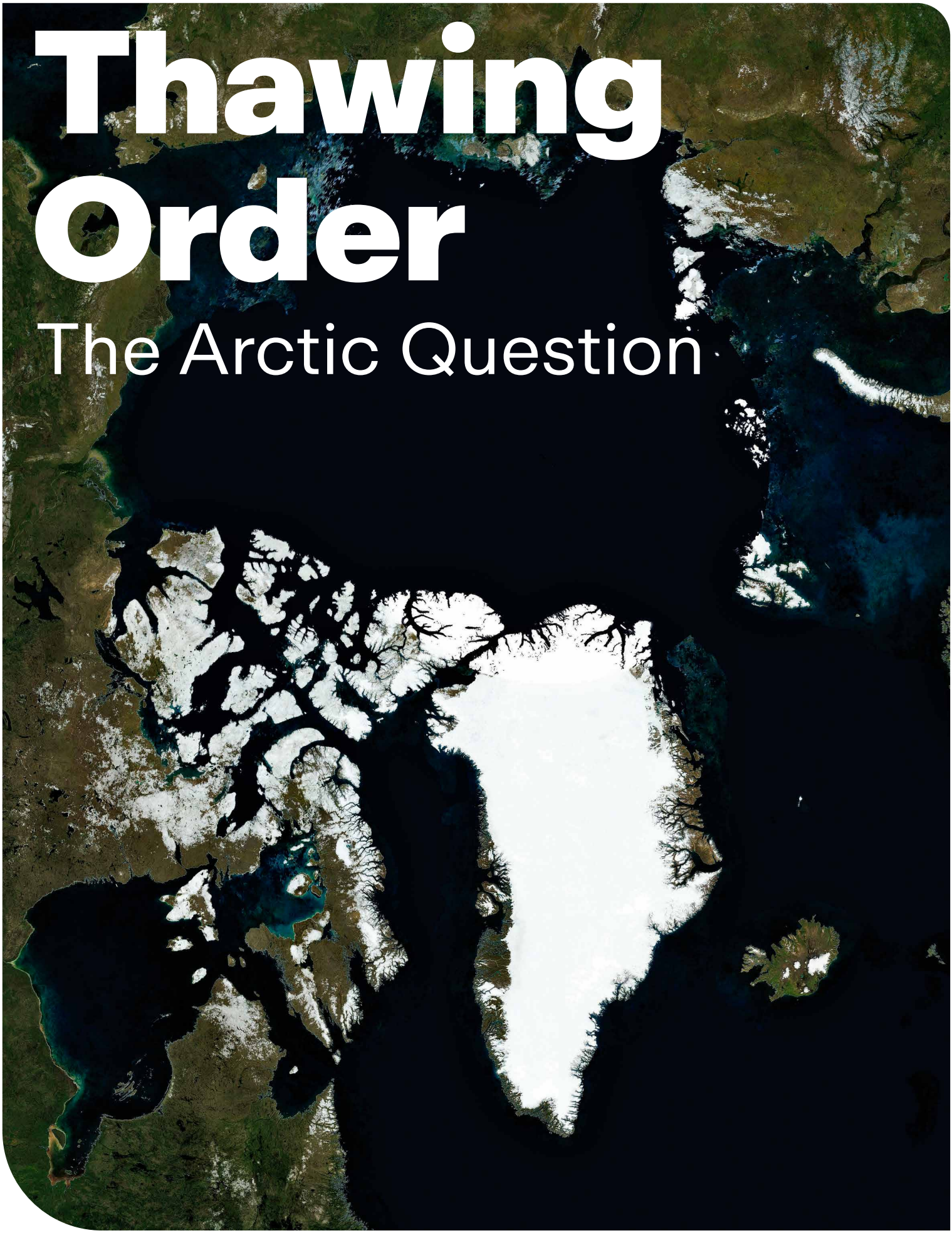
Thawing Order

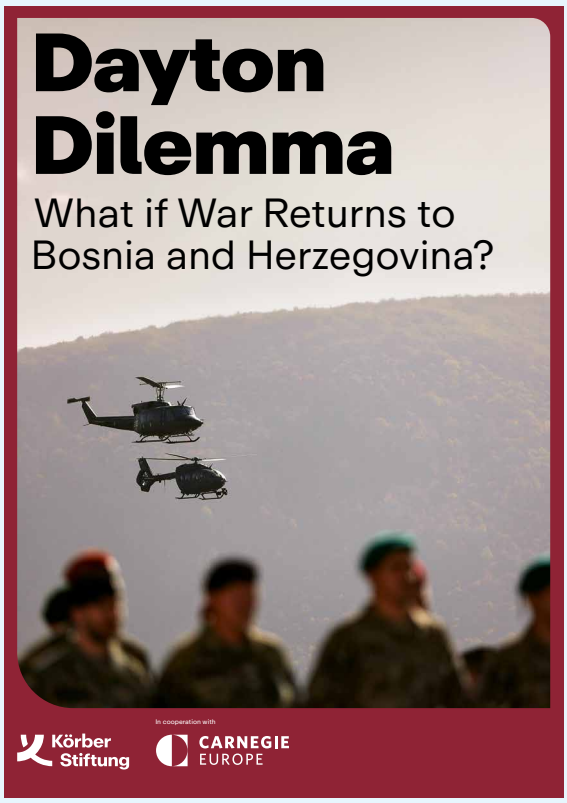
The Arctic Question



In cooperation with

Körber Stiftung

GCSP
Geneva Centre for Security Policy



Dayton Dilemma: What if War Returns to Bosnia and Herzegovina?

Despite decades of Western engagement and an ongoing EU accession process, the Western Balkans are once again on the brink. Political instability is deepening, economic pressures are mounting, and military tensions are rising, yet the region's future trajectory remains dangerously uncertain. A renewed military escalation in Bosnia and Herzegovina would be far more than a local crisis: it would be a direct test of whether Europe can still act strategically on its own continent. With war raging in Ukraine, transatlantic unity under strain, and EU cohesion faltering, Bosnia and Herzegovina risks becoming a symbol of European paralysis. But it could also become a turning point for renewed European leadership.

koerber-stiftung.de/en/projects/koerber-policy-game/results-2025/



From Bad to Worse: What if Russia Wins?

US support for Ukraine in its fight against Russian aggression is uncertain, and Europe's resolve is continuously being tested. After two and a half years of war and setbacks on the battlefield, the outlook for Ukraine remains challenging. Transatlantic relations are unpredictable in an US election year, which endangers the European security order. Moreover, the 'rules-based international order' is losing credibility, especially in the Global South. Autocratic powers such as China and Russia continue to undermine this framework, thereby weakening the influence of the West. Amid international crises and domestic political pressure, European countries need unity and strategic foresight now more than ever.

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Introduction

Keep Cool and Carry On



Leslie Schübel
Programme Director,
Körber-Stiftung



Philip Lott
Programme Manager,
Körber-Stiftung

Amid geopolitical turmoil, the Arctic region has become a testing ground for the defining challenges of our time. Accelerating climate change, a Greenland under strain and deepening tensions between cooperation and geopolitical competition are converging to make the region one of the most pivotal arenas in international relations. These challenges are inextricably linked: sanctions evasion opens the door to geopolitical influence, environmental shocks trigger humanitarian and political crises, and critical infrastructure becomes an instrument of coercion. Neglecting one dimension allows another to worsen. This year's Körber Policy Game was designed to test this dynamic by asking what would happen if the different challenges merged into a single one.

European actors navigate an increasingly contested Arctic. An escalating crisis involving Russia and China is no longer inconceivable with controversial investments in Greenland, hybrid threats and, ultimately, military signalling in the Greenland-Iceland-United Kingdom (GIUK) Gap. The exercise produced two key findings. First, preparedness must be prioritized. Rather than remaining reactive to unfolding events, European actors need to be ready for a wide range of eventualities before a crisis unfolds. Second, credibility is a precondition for everything else. Deterrence, coalition-building, burden-sharing and the ability to speak with one voice all depend on a coordinated and consistent European approach to the Arctic.

Bringing together teams from the Kingdom of Denmark, Germany, Norway, and the United Kingdom, the Körber Policy Game assessed policy options for responding to a crisis in the High North. How can competition be managed without triggering escalation? Which mechanisms can reduce risks and can existing governance frameworks still provide stability? How should European actors protect their economic and security interests as these become closely linked in a more confrontation-ridden Arctic?

The Körber Policy Game is based on the idea of translating plausible – not necessarily probable – developments of current foreign and security policy issues into a future scenario. It seeks to develop a deeper understanding of the interests and policy options of different actors. Previous Körber Policy Games have discussed a Russian victory in Ukraine, an escalation in the Taiwan Strait and destabilization in Bosnia and Herzegovina.

The Körber Policy Game, in cooperation with Julie Allard of the Geneva Centre for Security Policy (GCSP), took place in a confidential setting in Berlin in June 2026. This report summarizes the insights and positions generated by the Körber Policy Game.

Please note that the report reflects the authors' analysis of the exercise and not necessarily that of the participants or the organizations involved.

Executive Summary

From manageable tension to systemic crisis

Across three different moves, participants faced a progression from sanctions evasion and contested investments in Greenland to environmental disaster and hybrid disruption, and ultimately to military signalling and strategic confrontation involving Russia and China. A central insight was the fusion of risk domains. Financial loopholes enabled geopolitical influence; environmental shocks triggered humanitarian and political crises; and critical infrastructure – including undersea cables, ports and navigation systems – became instruments of coercion. These interdependencies compressed decision-making timelines and reduced the effectiveness of incremental responses.

Governance under pressure

Existing governance frameworks remained relevant but increasingly contested. Participants consistently emphasised the continued importance of the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), NATO, the Arctic Council (in its current mandate) and international regulatory regimes, while recognizing their limitations under stress. The challenge was not the absence of rules, but rather their selective application and competing interpretation. European credibility depends on consistent adherence to the standards it promotes, including in areas such as sanctions enforcement, navigation and resource governance. The exercise reinforced that effective Arctic governance requires institutional adaptation and political discipline, especially in an environment characterized by hybrid threats and attribution challenges.

Greenland as strategic pivot and vulnerability

Greenland was the geopolitical centre of gravity throughout the scenario. Economic collapse, dependence on external investment and strategic geography combined to create opportunity and vulnerability. Participants identified a fundamental dilemma: stabilizing Greenland economically is essential for regional security, yet doing so requires navigating external involvement without undermining Danish sovereignty or European strategic interests. The discussions also highlighted that long-term stability depends not only on financial support but also on sustainable development and local ownership, including diversification beyond extractive industries.

Indigenous communities at the core of Arctic stability

A critical takeaway from the scenario was the central importance of Indigenous communities, particularly in Greenland and across the Arctic region. Participants stressed that Indigenous populations are not simply vulnerable stakeholders and that they are essential actors in Arctic governance, with unique knowledge, political agency and rightful legitimacy. Strengthening Arctic resilience therefore requires the systematic inclusion of Indigenous perspectives in decision-making, particularly in environmental management, emergency response and long-term economic development.

Alliance dynamics and the need for coordination

The later stages of the scenario highlighted challenges to European and transatlantic cohesion. Unilateral actions, differing threat perceptions and varying escalation thresholds risked undermining coordinated responses. Participants stressed that clear red lines, pre-agreed coordination mechanisms and structured division of labour are essential to prevent miscalculation and maintain deterrence. Sustained engagement with the United States was seen as indispensable, even amid uncertainty regarding its policy, while strengthening European capabilities emerged as a key priority to reduce structural dependencies.

Shared but uneven responsibility

While all four country teams aimed to prevent escalation and preserve stability, their approaches reflected different priorities and strategic cultures. Germany focused on upholding the rules-based order and preventing escalation, combining diplomatic engagement with economic stabilization efforts. The United Kingdom emphasised deterrence, maritime security and pragmatic coalition-building alongside de-escalation, particularly in countering Russia and limiting Chinese influence. Denmark prioritized Greenland's stability, sovereignty and crisis management, balancing domestic responsibilities with alliance dynamics. Norway adopted a strategy of continuity and restraint, emphasising situational awareness, regional expertise and de-escalation. These differences reinforce the importance of burden-sharing based on comparative advantage, rather than centralized coordination, as a practical model for European engagement in the Arctic.

Building a coherent European approach

The policy discussions converged around the need for a more coordinated and proactive European role in the Arctic. Key priorities include strengthening financial enforcement and sanctions integrity, providing credible alternatives to external investment in Greenland, enhancing maritime awareness and infrastructure protection, and developing joint crisis-response mechanisms for environmental and hybrid threats as well as improving EU-NATO coordination, while respecting the functional differences between institutions. Preparation and coordination ahead of crises were identified as decisive factors in shaping outcomes, rather than reactive measures once escalation is underway.

The Arctic as a test of order

The case of the Arctic illustrates how climate change and geopolitical competition are reshaping the strategic landscape. It is no longer a peripheral region; it is a front-line environment where the future of international cooperation and competition is being negotiated in real time. The central challenge for European actors is not only to prevent further escalation, but also to ensure that competition remains bounded by credible rules, supported by consistent enforcement and balanced by continued cooperation. How Europe responds in the Arctic will have implications far beyond the region. It will be a benchmark for its ability to act strategically in an increasingly contested world.

Methodology

The Körber Policy Game is based on a short-to-medium-term scenario of three escalating moves, which is provided to participants on the day of the event. The scenario does not attempt to predict the future and it is not a forecasting tool. Rather, it is a tool to enable participants to discuss the policy game's guiding questions and the interests as well as the policy options of different actors in concrete terms. To limit the complexity of the scenario, it is generally based on the assumption that the current state of affairs is projected into the future in all aspects not explicitly mentioned. The context of the scenario is therefore in most respects a linear continuation of the current situation. Participants in the Körber Policy Game are senior experts and officials from four countries (this year: the Kingdom of Denmark, Germany, Norway, and the United Kingdom).



Julie Allard
Deputy Director,
Mediation and Peace
Support, GCSP

The Scenario

Thawing Order

2030–2031

In March 2030, Western intelligence services uncover that Russian entities are using shell companies registered in Greenland to bypass Western sanctions. Investigations by several European financial intelligence units, coordinated through the EU's Anti-Money Laundering Authority, expose a network of front companies operating through a financial services hub in Nuuk. The scheme centres on selling Russian Arctic liquefied natural gas and crude oil to European buyers through Greenlandic intermediaries, masking the origin of the shipments and thus circumventing sanctions on Russian energy exports. Suspicious transactions are traced through international correspondent banking chains, including clearing accounts held at Barclays in London and Deutsche Bank in Frankfurt.

At the same time, Greenland faces an acute economic crisis. An unprecedented warming of the oceans, sudden changes in ocean currents and disruptions to the Atlantic Meridional Overturning Circulation have led to the rapid collapse of the halibut and shrimp fisheries off the coast of Greenland. As these fisheries account for more than 80 per cent of Greenland's export revenue, Royal Greenland, the state-owned fishing company and one of the largest employers, declares insolvency, triggering mass unemployment and raising urgent questions about Greenland's fiscal viability. The disruption to Arctic fisheries and shipping routes has knock-on effects in the Barents Sea, with the diminution of fish stocks leading to heightened tensions between international fishing fleets operating near maritime boundaries.

In the autumn, Prime Minister Múte Egede initiates a necessary new round of licensing for the exploitation of critical minerals and rare earths to stabilize the economy following the collapse of the fishing sector. Talks with a European consortium backed by the European Investment Bank drag on before collapsing over three unresolved issues: environmental standards, infrastructure financing and long-term offtake guarantees. Shortly thereafter, Polaris Resource Holdings, a company registered in Singapore, steps in and acquires a majority stake in the key rare earth mining project in western Greenland. The Danish newspaper *Jyllands-Posten* later reveals that Polaris Resource Holdings is a shell entity controlled by a Chinese state-linked mining conglomerate. The agreement includes plans to construct a deep-water port to support future extraction and exportation operations.

In July 2031, Denmark introduces a new regulatory and fee regime for vessels operating through northern Greenlandic sea lanes as melting summer sea ice has led to a sharp increase in shipping in the Arctic. The government cites its rights under UNCLOS to adopt non-discriminatory measures for environmental monitoring costs and maritime safety obligations in ice-covered Arctic waters. Amid international criticism, several ships from a Chinese commercial fleet refuse to comply, triggering a maritime standoff that prompts Denmark's Joint Arctic Command to deploy patrol vessels to the area to enforce compliance. China condemns what it calls unlawful restrictions on freedom of navigation, arguing that de facto transit fees violate UNCLOS.

2033

Shortly after Iceland's EU accession in January 2033, Reykjavik reports unusual submarine activity off its southern and western coasts, with unidentified vessels operating near undersea cables. Though there is no formal attribution, NATO intelligence increasingly points to Russia. Across the GIUK gap, Automatic Identification System (AIS) tracking reveals a sharp rise in GPS interference affecting vessel navigation.

In September, as a storm front approaches, the fully laden oil tanker *NS Champion*, transiting Baffin Bay between Greenland and Canada, runs aground after experiencing suspected GPS interference that disrupted its navigation systems. The incident triggers a massive oil spill in this ecologically extremely fragile environment. While the tanker operates under the Liberian flag, media reports indicate that it has belonged to Russia's crude-oil shadow fleet for many years.

Within 48 hours, an unprecedented Arctic mega-storm descends on the affected area. It forces all search-and-rescue vessels to withdraw, leaving the tanker crew stranded. For nearly a week, no meaningful containment or recovery operations

are possible. All 20 crew members are rescued after weather conditions improve and response teams reach the site. The mega-storm results in several injured people in Sisimiut due to debris from damaged buildings, while five fishermen are reported missing with their vessel lost at sea.

Oil has spread extensively beneath drifting ice. Environmental assessments indicate that the damage is effectively irreversible. As the *NS Champion* operated outside the Western insurance system, no credible liability coverage exists to fund a clean-up or compensation, leaving Canadian and Danish taxpayers facing costs that analysts estimate could run into the tens of billions of US dollars. Lloyd's of London, which insures a significant share of Arctic shipping, places all legitimate instances of it under emergency review, triggering premium increases that threaten to price operators off Arctic routes entirely.

The spill devastates wildlife populations and destroys key hunting grounds relied upon by Inuit communities in Greenland. Local leaders issue urgent appeals for international assistance as local food sources become inaccessible or contaminated. Images of oil-covered wildlife and food shortages in remote settlements spread rapidly on social media, generating intense international public pressure. In Oslo, hundreds of Sámi activists block streets and set up protest camps in solidarity with the Inuit communities in Greenland to demand their protection.

Already weakened by the collapse of its fishing sector, Greenland now faces the near-total breakdown of its remaining coastal economy. The mega-storm's impacts also trigger a large-scale evacuation of foreign workers from mining and infrastructure projects; thousands are airlifted out, including a significant number of Chinese personnel. China's minister of foreign affairs reaches out to his Greenlandic counterpart to offer a humanitarian air bridge. Given Greenland's sensitive flight infrastructure, the prospect of Chinese military transport aircraft at Kangerlussuaq or Nuuk prompts concern. The Polaris port is left inoperable, casting uncertainty over the future of critical mineral production in the region.

2035

By March 2035, over a year after the mega-storm, Greenland is slowly recovering but its economy remains shattered. Arctic shipping keeps increasing, and despite damage to the Polaris port, Chinese commercial activity has quietly resumed, with Chinese navy ships routinely escorting container vessels through northern sea lanes to 'protect' Chinese interests. Beijing separately pursues UNCLOS arbitration against Denmark's 2031 transit fee regime.

Amid this tension, the Greenland Connect cables linking Greenland to Iceland and Canada are severed, largely cutting Greenland off from the internet and degrading civilian, government and military communications, forcing reliance on slower satellite links. Norway and Denmark attribute the act with high confidence to a Russian submarine. US President JD Vance publicly offers Starlink connectivity in exchange for preferential access to Greenland's resources, without consulting Denmark.

Days later, an unmarked aircraft enters the GIUK Gap on a surveillance flight. NATO intercepts it, assesses it as Russian and a threat after it fails to respond, and shoots it down. Moscow denies involvement and lodges a UN Security Council complaint condemning an 'unprovoked act of aggression', a position backed by several non-Western states, including China.

In response, Russia declares the GIUK Gap a zone of special military interest. Its Northern Fleet begins overt submarine patrols from Kola Peninsula bases, which are tracked transiting the Bear Island Gap before entering the North Atlantic. Days later, a Russian submarine surfaces near Pituffik Space Base in Greenland. The US submarine *USS Annapolis* is repositioned to shadow it without prior NATO coordination, with Denmark notified only afterward.

Russia also invokes the 1920 Svalbard Treaty to demand access for its vessels to resupply at Longyearbyen. Norway cannot deny signatories equal commercial access under the treaty, and no such request has ever been refused. Though the ships are registered to the state mining company Arktikugol, US intelligence indicates their manifests understate their true cargo.

Russia and China issue a joint statement calling the Western military presence in Arctic waters a threat to regional stability and announce a joint naval exercise in the Barents Sea. As the Arctic Council chair, Iceland invites member and observer states, including China, to an emergency meeting in Reykjavik. US Secretary of State Josh Hawley sharply criticizes the invitation as rewarding a provocateur and announces the United States will not attend.

Policy Recommendations

1. Play to strengths, share the burden

Responsibility in the Arctic should follow comparative advantage rather than centralized command. Oslo, Copenhagen and Nuuk are best placed to lead on Arctic security and Greenlandic affairs given their proximity and expertise, while Germany and the United Kingdom contribute through naval presence, funding and diplomatic weight. NATO should remain the channel for dealing with hybrid and military threats, the Arctic Council for environmental and Indigenous concerns, and the EU for economic instruments. This prevents duplication of efforts and ensures that the actor with the relevant capability and legitimacy leads on each issue.

2. Credibility requires consistency

European credibility in the Arctic rests on applying the same rules to allies as to adversaries. Insisting on UNCLOS compliance, freedom of navigation and sanctions enforcement against Russia and China only holds weight if European states observe the same standards in their own conduct, including in shipping and resource extraction. Double standards or demands that Europe itself would not meet erode legitimacy and give Moscow and Beijing grounds to dismiss European positions as political rather than principled. A credible Arctic policy must be one Europe is prepared to live by.

3. Do not give up on the United States

No European Arctic strategy can succeed by excluding or working around Washington. Germany's assessment that there is no path forward against the United States, the United Kingdom's reliance on its 'special relationship', and Denmark and Norway's dependence on US engagement for Greenlandic stability and NATO's northern flank all point to the same conclusion. Europe should sustain active outreach to Washington through bilateral and NATO channels, while exploring a US economic role in Greenland's development and avoid steps that would push it toward disengagement or unilateral action in the region.

4. Close the capability gaps

Europe's reliance on US military capacity and its exposure to Chinese capital are structural vulnerabilities rather than temporary gaps. Building European alternatives in rare earths, critical infrastructure and a coordinated Arctic platform would give Greenland a genuine alternative to Chinese investment, while a stronger European naval footprint in the GIUK Gap would reduce dependence on the US presence. Where military capability cannot be borrowed from allies on reasonable terms, Europe should build it domestically. The aim must be a shift from dependency to autonomy, not improvised substitution in a crisis.

5. Define red lines

Ambiguity in the Arctic invites escalation rather than preventing it. GPS spoofing, shadow-fleet activity and military exercises near European territory should be met based on pre-agreed thresholds rather than improvised responses, and communicated through NATO's Article 4 consultations rather than ad hoc bilateral signalling. Attribution, as Norway and Germany stressed, is a precondition for deterrence to function. At the same time, the threshold for invoking NATO's Article 5 should remain high and explicit. Red lines are only credible if they are defined and communicated before, not during, a crisis.

6. Coordinate and prepare

Pre-emptive coordination across domains limits the room for rivals to exploit a crisis as it unfolds. This means pre-arranged humanitarian and economic support for Greenland that can be delivered faster than Chinese offers, joint contingency planning with Canada and Denmark for environmental emergencies, agreed messaging toward Beijing without closing off diplomatic channels and a clear division between NATO and the Arctic Council on dealing with security and governance issues. Preparation set in motion before a crisis, not improvisation during one, will determine whether Europe shapes Arctic events or merely reacts to them.

Interests and Policy Options

What if the High North Becomes a Focal Point of Geopolitical Competition?

Considering a scenario marked by escalating political and military tensions in the Arctic as well as growing economic and environmental impacts of climate change, the four teams defined their countries' interests and formulated policy options. The following sections outline the crisis response that the teams would recommend to their country's government in this scenario.

Kingdom of Denmark
Greenland (and more)

The team summarized Denmark's interests according to a concise but complex formula: keep Greenland up (and running), keep the United States down, keep China out, and keep the EU and Denmark in. Simultaneously, the team recognized the complexity of the relationship between Nuuk and Copenhagen and how this determines the scope of interests and policy options. In general, the team assumed that such a crisis would result in greater alignment between them. However, the embedding of the relationship within a wider network of allies (NATO, EU, Nordic countries) would shape the room for manoeuvre just as much as the broader geopolitical context.

Overall, the response of the Danish team was twofold. In the immediate term, effective crisis management would be the principal priority. This would require addressing the economic collapse and the environmental disaster affecting Greenland in close coordination with local authorities and in accordance with Greenlandic needs. Cash payouts would be an option to reassure the population, and humanitarian aid would have to be provided rapidly. It would be paramount to act with allies faster than China, not only in ensuring emergency relief but also in developing alternatives to Chinese investments. Additionally, close coordination with Canada would lead to on-the-ground solutions for local security.

Beyond the immediate response, the Danish team identified the long-term development and resilience of Greenlandic society as the central strategic challenge. It argued that sustainable stabilization would depend on meaningful local ownership and the systematic inclusion of the Greenlandic population in future decision-making. An economic development plan that extends beyond fisheries and critical minerals could place greater emphasis on sectors such as renewable energy and tourism. This could also provide an opportunity for mutually beneficial cooperation with the United States while reducing Greenland's long-term economic vulnerabilities.



The Danish team further cautioned against treating every incident in the Arctic as a crisis. It argued that developments such as mega-storms and GPS interference have become recurring

features of the regional security environment, and that they should continue to be managed through tried-and-tested procedures unless they reach a threshold that fundamentally alters the strategic situation, which would require measures beyond established routines.

The focus on domestic issues would leave many aspects of security entrusted to others. Responses to Russian submarine operations and GPS interference would have to be primarily developed by the EU and NATO, with the latter in the lead on collective defence. The Danish team assessed that further deterioration in the GIUK Gap could lead to consideration of triggering NATO's Article 5 in case of further escalation. Regarding Svalbard, the Kingdom of Denmark would firmly support Norway's stance while strictly maintaining that issues concerning sovereignty and security should remain outside the mandate of the Arctic Council.



Germany
De-escalate at all costs

The team viewed the evolving situation in the Arctic as directly connected to core priorities of Germany's foreign and security policy. Despite the country's non-Arctic status, the team saw an interest in, and the need for, its active engagement to address significant implications for European security and the international order.

Germany would have two priorities in this scenario. On the one hand, upholding the rules-based international order is a central concern for it. This would require pressuring allies and adversaries to adhere to legal frameworks such as UNCLOS. Furthermore, international sanctions regimes, as in the case of Russia, would need to be safeguarded together with European partners.

On the other hand, the German team prioritized preventing further escalation at all costs. In the short term, this would entail the establishment and use of 'red telephones' with Russia and supporting Norway as a direct and reliable interlocutor with the Kremlin. For the medium term, the German team suggested measures to rebuild confidence, which could ultimately result in the development of a Vienna Document 2.0. In order to prevent a scenario that could trigger the use of NATO's Article 5, the German team was open to expressing regret and apologizing to Russia over the incident involving a Russian aircraft. This raised questions about which lessons Germany has drawn from Russia's war against Ukraine and its hybrid meddling along NATO's eastern flank in previous years.

The German team consistently approached the individual elements of the scenario through the lens of stability. In the case of Greenland, economic stability would be crucial to prevent geopolitical fallout. The German team suggested flexible solutions that could range from offering targeted funding to structured EU assistance or even the possibility of EU accession.

Addressing the strategic competition with China would require offering alternatives to Greenland when it comes to Chinese investment, and reaching out to Nuuk and Copenhagen in order to identify specific needs. The German team was convinced that the attractiveness of high environmental and social standards in the EU context could create windows of opportunity for Germany to 'jump in' together with partners. Nonetheless, Germany should avoid discord with China while keeping in mind that Beijing would also not want a militarization of the Arctic, according to the team's assessment.

Regarding Russia, the German team advocated a deterrence-based approach. Credible attribution of GPS interference would have a deterring effect, and NATO could act with a clear mandate based on Article 4 consultations. Moreover, NATO would be key for coordinating a strong European footprint throughout the Arctic region. Especially in the GIUK Gap, allies would need to establish a credible force posture in the face of Russian provocations. Moreover, this would contribute to ensuring safety of navigation.

The environmental disaster in Baffin Bay would illustrate interdependence and lead to an example of how positioning against China and Russia can go hand-in-hand. The German team argued that strengthening international shipping standards through the International Maritime Organization, alongside reforms to maritime-insurance mechanisms, would reduce the likelihood of similar incidents in the future. Linking the first crisis (Russia's GPS interference) with the second crisis (an oil spill originating from Russia's shadow fleet) would help establish a coherent narrative regarding Russian responsibility. Such an approach could command broad international support by the

United States, Canada and even China. German engagement in mitigating the consequences of the oil spill by providing support (evacuation, clean-up, rebuilding) to Canada and Greenland would undercut the attractiveness of Chinese initiatives. A funding conference for the sustainable recovery of Greenland could prevent the further geopoliticization of its future.

Finally, the German team emphasised that any sustainable approach to Arctic security would require continued engagement with the United States. While recognizing Washington as an indispensable actor, the team acknowledged considerable uncertainty regarding the future direction of US policy.

Norway
Arctic routines

The Norwegian team adopted a strategy centred on preservation and continuity. This included protection of the global order as a reliable status quo, emphasising support for UNCLOS, freedom of navigation and the integrity of international sanctions regimes. Furthermore, Norway should strive for continued stability and avoid escalation, regionally and globally.

To this end, the Norwegian team emphasised the importance of getting the picture right and ensuring the accuracy of intelligence. Instead of over-dramatizing individual incidents, situational awareness in the Arctic should be increased and intelligence-sharing and coordination encouraged among allies. Norway would be well placed to serve as 'eyes and ears' in the Arctic and, as a direct neighbour, to maintain a direct channel of communication with Russia.

From the Norwegian perspective, there should be a clear division of tasks: local problems require local solutions and Arctic expertise is necessary to address issues in the High North. In the team's view, the Arctic states possess extensive regional expertise and have developed an effective institutional toolkit over decades of cooperation. Consequently, existing mechanisms should be utilized wherever possible, with new instruments developed only where established formats prove insufficient. The team acknowledged that the Arctic is interconnected and thus that developments such as moving fish stocks due to climate change will have knock-on effects in the Barents Sea and direct implications for Norway's national interests.

In practice, this means that the situation in Greenland would be primarily Nuuk and Copenhagen's responsibility. Norway would be prepared to contribute to joint efforts in response to economic and environmental crises – including by providing technical expertise in areas such as oil-spill response – but with the Kingdom of Denmark in the lead.

The Norwegian team viewed GPS interference as an issue extending beyond the Arctic and requiring broader international attention. Given the similar experiences in Finnmark, Norway should coordinate closely with Iceland and provide support where necessary while also seeking to elevate the issue to multilateral forums. In particular, it identified the United Nations, the International Maritime Organization and NATO (including consultations under Article 4) as appropriate frameworks for developing coordinated responses.

The Norwegian team wanted the Arctic Council to play a central role in advancing and improving governance in, for and of the Arctic in the medium term, with a focus on resource allocation, environment and Indigenous issues. However, the Arctic Council should not be involved in issues of security and defence.

Accordingly, Norway would deal with matters related to Svalbard and the Barents Sea as a question of upholding and exercising its sovereignty and as a primary, national responsibility. However, the Norwegian team argued that Sino-Russian military exercises and Russian requests to resupply at Longyearbyen should initially be treated as routine. This would mean managing them as standard procedure and relying on established formats and courses of action. Even if Russia's actions were to become more assertive, Norway would remain in control and handle this quietly and ideally bilaterally. At the same time, the team acknowledged that this restrained approach might not be shared by all allies, particularly the United Kingdom, making close coordination within NATO essential to secure political support, especially in response to hybrid threats.



China featured less prominently in the Norwegian team's considerations. Nevertheless, Norway should pursue a strategic approach to critical minerals as self-sufficiency is not only resource policy but also foreign policy.

United Kingdom
Global questions, local partners

The British team approached the escalating situation in the Arctic through two overarching prisms. First, the outlined developments and their impacts would extend well beyond the High North as the Arctic is a global issue. Second, norms and established mechanisms of governance might not match the security considerations. Consequently, the United Kingdom should acknowledge the necessity of pragmatism when defining its role.

The British team identified Russia as the principal security threat. Accordingly, continued support for Ukraine would still be a priority and require the commitment of resources. Within the context of the scenario, confronting the Russian shadow fleet and strengthening the integrity of sanctions regimes would require additional British efforts. The team further emphasised that credible attribution of hostile activities, including GPS interference, to Russia or Russian-backed actors would be essential for maintaining deterrence, which requires clear and decisive communication. At the same time, using back channels through allied members of the Arctic Council would be a valuable option for de-escalation during periods of heightened tension.

The British team framed China as a strategic challenger whose ambitions also extend into the Arctic. Accordingly, establishing precedents such as a Chinese-led humanitarian air bridge or a mining consortium in Greenland should be avoided. Instead, the United Kingdom, with like-minded partners, should take the initiative and position itself as a credible alternative by providing political, economic and logistical support where appropriate. In this regard, the British team considered the United Kingdom's approach toward Russia and China to rest on three pillars: deter, challenge and de-escalate.



The British team attached particular importance to developments in the GIUK Gap, regarding it as directly linked to homeland defence. Therefore, securing British infrastructure such as undersea cables in this area and increasing the Royal Navy's presence would be immediate priorities. The team also addressed two other issues of domestic concern. First, the impact of climate change on fisheries has direct implications for the United Kingdom and the team emphasised the need to pursue cooperative arrangements capable of reducing tensions over maritime resources. Second, London should seek to preserve its position as a shipping hub and support its businesses, such as Lloyds, as Arctic shipping continues to evolve.

The United Kingdom could count on a wide range of partnerships and use further context-specific cooperation frameworks if necessary. The guiding principle should be identifying where its interests converge with those of allies and partners. First, the United Kingdom would support its Arctic partners where needed and requested, backing up Norway in the case of Svalbard and providing support to Nuuk and Copenhagen in response to the environmental and economic crisis in Greenland. London should still aim to build on the special relationship and try to bring in the United States, even if the role of its administration remains the central 'known unknown'. Perceiving the Arctic as a global issue requires a global response with NATO (possibly including the Indo-Pacific Four) and Canada as possible co-responders. The EU would be a preferred partner but if alignment is difficult, cooperation with it would not be the first priority. Instead, necessary flexibility could be provided by agile arrangements such as coalitions of the willing or working groups, possibly convened under British leadership in the context of the Joint Expeditionary Force.

Overall, the British team was open to drawing on lessons learned in other areas, in particular the Indo-Pacific and the South China Sea, as well as from the recent situation in the Strait of Hormuz as they offer relevant precedents for managing contested maritime spaces, hybrid threats and strategic competition. Applying these lessons to the Arctic would strengthen the United Kingdom's ability to respond to an increasingly complex security environment while avoiding the need to develop entirely new policy approaches.

Learning to Prepare for the Unpredictable

Reflections from the Körber Policy Game 2026



Aaja Chemnitz
Partner, Inuva.gl;
Former Member of the Folketing,
Inuit Ataqatigiit

The greatest challenges in foreign and security policy are often the ones we do not see coming. While governments spend considerable time preparing for known risks, the world has a habit of presenting us with scenarios that test our assumptions, alliances and ability to adapt. That is precisely what makes the Körber Policy Game so worthwhile.

The simulation created an environment in which participants could challenge each other's thinking, test policy responses under pressure and explore the difficult trade-offs that leaders face during international crises. Exercises like these are essential because they allow us to learn before events unfold in the real world.

From a Greenlandic perspective, the discussions carried particular significance. Greenland has become increasingly central to international attention because of its strategic location, its natural resources and the changing geopolitical landscape in the Arctic. But, while global powers often view it through a strategic lens, it is important to remember that Greenland is first and foremost home to a people with democratic institutions, political ambitions and the right to determine their own future.

One of my key takeaways from the exercise is that crisis management alone is not enough. We also need long-term strategic planning. It would have been particularly valuable to also work on the development of a comprehensive master plan for Greenland-United States relations. This could have produced concrete recommendations for how to strengthen dialogue, reduce misunderstandings and build resilient partnerships before tensions arise. Preparing for crises is important, but preventing them through stronger relationships is even better.

The Körber Policy Game also demonstrates how interconnected today's security challenges have become. Decisions made in one capital quickly affect partners across the Atlantic and the Arctic. That makes trust, communication and mutual understanding more important than ever. Greenland cannot simply be treated as an object of great-power competition; Greenlanders must be active participants in shaping the policies that concern their future.

Opportunities to engage with participants from different countries remain crucial. The discussions were thoughtful, constructive and conducted in a spirit of mutual respect. At the same time, I found myself wondering how the conversations might have evolved with an even broader range of perspectives. Most participants came from countries with relatively similar outlooks on international affairs. Future iterations could be even richer by including countries whose strategic perspectives differ more significantly from those of Europe and North America. Challenging our assumptions is often where the greatest learning takes place.

Ultimately, the value of exercises like the Körber Policy Game lies not in predicting the future perfectly, but in strengthening our ability to respond wisely when the unexpected happens. In an increasingly uncertain world, that kind of preparation is indispensable.

I leave the Körber Policy Game with many valuable insights, a deeper appreciation for international cooperation and renewed conviction that Greenland's voice must continue to be part of the conversations shaping the future of the Arctic and the wider international order.





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Körber-Stiftung
Berlin Office
Pariser Platz 4a
10117 Berlin, Germany
Phone +49 · 30 · 20 62 67 - 60
E-mail ip@koerber-stiftung.de
koerber-stiftung.de/en
LinkedIn Körber-Stiftung IP

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